

Passages - An Immense World

The robin can feel Earth's magnetic field, and, guided by its internal compass, it points due south and escapes through a window.

Every animal can only tap into a small fraction of reality's fullness. Each is enclosed within its own unique sensory bubble, perceiving but a tiny sliver of an immense world. (Unwelten)

To sense the world, animals detect stimuli-quantities like light, sound, or chemicals-and convert them into electrical signals, which travel along neurons toward the brain.

We harm animals by filling the world with stimuli that overwhelm or befuddle their senses. We misinterpret the needs of animals closest to us, imposing the visual world of humans upon them.

All is not as it seems...everything we experience is but a filtered version of everything that we could experience. There is light in darkness, noise in silence, richness in nothingness.

Smells travel through darkness, around corners, and in other conditions that vex vision. Smells linger in a way that light does not, revealing history.

Female lobsters urinate into the faces of males to tempt them with a sex pheromone.

DMS is the scent of bountiful seas, where huge blooms of plankton feed equally huge swarms of krill.

Taste is mostly a final check before consumption

We tend to wrongly equate taste with flavor, when the latter is more dominated by smell. That's why food seems bland when you have a cold: Its taste is the same, but the flavor dims because you can't smell it.

The stinger of a parasitic wasp is like a Swiss army knife. Aside from taste sensors, it can also carry smell sensors, touch sensors, and bits of metal. It's a drill, a nose, a tongue, and a hand.

The most extensive sense of taste in nature surely belongs to catfish these fish are swimming tongues. They have taste buds spread all over their scale-free bodies, from the tips of their whisker-like barbels to their tails.

It's possible that if a random Australian bird hadn't expanded its Umwelt tens of millions of years ago, none of us would be waking up to the melodic sounds of birdsong today.

Opsins are special because they keep hold of their target molecules, and because those molecules absorb light. This is the entire basis of vision. This is how all animals see using light-sensitive proteins that are actually modified chemical sensors.

In a way, we see by smelling light.